

White smoke at Volkswagen

送信者: POLITICO Pro Morning Mobility Europe 受信日時: 2026-09-04 14:05

【要点】

- フォルクスワーゲンの取締役会がCEO オリバー・ブルーメの経費削減計画を承認し、2030年までに5万人の雇用削減と4つのドイツ工場の閉鎖を実施することが決定された。
- 同社は前回7月の承認申請に必要な票を獲得できず、今回2度目の提案で満場一致の承認を得た。
- VWは2030年までに年900万台の販売と9%の営業利益率を目標とし、製品ラインアップの半減や経営の簡素化など複数の改革施策を実行する。
- 強い反対姿勢を示していた労働組合IG Metallも最終的に計画を支持し、労働者の利益保護と企業の競争力強化のバランスを取る形で合意に至った。

【メール原文】

Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure. By MARTINA SAPIO with JORDYN DAHL SNEAK PEEK — Volkswagen's board approved CEO

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with JORDYN DAHL

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SNEAK PEEK

— Volkswagen's board approved CEO Oliver Blume's cost-cutting plan that would cut up to 50,000 jobs and shutter four factories.

— Europe's airlines say they're facing a triple threat this fall — an expiring border-system safety valve, a wider ETS and too little support for sustainable fuels.

— Norwegian authorities have seized a Russian commercial vessel in the Arctic, just as Moscow lobbies to expand year-round shipping along its Northern Sea Route.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

Tips to jdahl@politico.eu , tlecca@politico.eu and msapio@politico.eu . Follow us @tommylecca , @jordyndahl and @martsapio .

Mark your calendars: Our weekly mobility calendar landed in your inbox on Thursday. You can also go online to export and plan your week or suggest your own event.

DRIVING THE DAY

VW BOARD APPROVES COST-CUTTING PLAN: Volkswagen's supervisory board late Thursday unanimously approved cost-cutting measures proposed by CEO Oliver Blume, agreeing to cut 50,000 jobs by 2030, trim the company's product line and shutter four German factories — Emden, Zwickau, Hanover and Neckarsulm. Including the 50,000 job losses previously agreed, the company would lose 100,000 positions.

Second time lucky: Blume had failed to get the necessary votes during his first appeal to the board in July. "The Supervisory Board has unanimously approved the Executive Board's Future Plan presented today," he said in a statement. "We are taking responsibility for our entire team, for our partners and for industrial jobs worldwide. Over the coming years, we will invest a three-figure billion sum to make our iconic brands even more attractive, stronger and more competitive."

Key points: Apart from the job cuts, VW said it will target 9 million annual vehicle sales and a 9 percent operating margin by 2030; cut its model portfolio by half; streamline operations, improve processes and reduce costs; simplify governance; focus its North American and Chinese businesses on profitable growth; and reduce non-core investments by about one-third.

Union green light: While the powerful worker's union IG Metall had come out swinging against the plan, and ministers had warned against shortchanging workers, everyone ultimately got on board. "In this crisis situation, we fought hard for good solutions ... It is good that the Executive Board now has the foundation to tackle the major tasks ahead," Christiane Benner, deputy chair of the board and chair of IG Metall said in a statement.

"Today's resolution sends important signs: We are investing heavily in future viability and are improving competitiveness ... We need a competitive framework and a trade policy that strengthens our industrial base in an increasingly fierce global competition," added Olaf Lies, premier of Lower Saxony, where VW is headquartered.

VW is unique among automakers in that representatives from both the worker's union and politicians from Lower Saxony sit on its supervisory board. That means they would have had to sign off on any reduction plan.

Election catnip: The far-right Alternative for Germany has capitalized on the VW crisis and the automaker's storied role in German society to lure in more voters, blaming the cuts on Chancellor Friedrich Merz's economic strategy and the EU's climate agenda that initially introduced the de facto 2035 combustion engine ban. And as the country heads into the first of three state elections this weekend, the AfD is close to winning an outright majority in Sunday's vote in Saxony-Anhalt.

Jordyn has more here on what the crisis means for Germany's political future.

****Could the AfD take power in Saxony-Anhalt?** POLITICO's James Angelos and Nette Nöstlinger will unpack the state election results and what they could mean for the AfD's ambitions, Germany's centrist parties and Chancellor Friedrich Merz's government. Join us for an online Pro briefing on Tuesday, Sept. 8 at 4 p.m. CEST. Register here .**

AVIATION

AVIATION'S FALL TURBULENCE: Europe's airlines are heading into a busy fall season with three fights at the top of their agenda: preventing airport chaos as a border-system safety valve expires, resisting a wider aviation ETS and securing enough support to make sustainable fuels commercially viable, IATA said at its rentrée briefing on Thursday.

Competitiveness first: IATA argues that airlines are being asked to absorb mounting compliance costs while also financing their transition. European carriers spent an estimated €9.9 billion on compliance in 2024, it said, and sustainable aviation fuel can cost up to four times as much as conventional jet fuel. The group wants the next EU budget's Competitiveness Fund to support European SAF production rather than leave airlines paying more for fuels that remain scarce.

Aviation strategy incoming: Brussels' upcoming aviation strategy is another opportunity, according to IATA, to set investment priorities and deliver the Commission's promised reduction in administrative burdens. The group wants more interoperable reporting across the EU ETS, the U.N.'s CORSIA scheme and other environmental rules, as well as simpler access to European funding.

ETS battle: IATA stressed that it does not oppose carbon pricing in principle. Its problem is the Commission's proposed expansion of the geographical scope of the aviation ETS, which it argues would impose European costs on portions of international journeys outside EU jurisdiction and potentially duplicate CORSIA obligations. The lobby warned that other large markets could respond with their own regional systems, fragmenting global aviation rules.

One system, please: IATA continues to defend CORSIA as the proper global framework, even while acknowledging that it is imperfect. Its argument is that airlines should not pay twice for the same emissions or navigate an expanding patchwork of overlapping schemes.

Borderline ready: Then there is the EU Entry/Exit System. The current flexibility allowing member countries to suspend EES temporarily when the system is overloaded and return to manual checks expires on Sept. 6. IATA said it was not aware of any formal Commission decision extending the suspension flexibility beyond Sept. 6 and wants clarity urgently.

Summer scars: The lobby said passengers missing connections because of border disruption doubled over the summer, with increases of up to sixfold for some airlines on peak days. Processing times sometimes tripled, while queues reached six hours in the most extreme cases — although performance varied considerably between airports.

The readiness test: Before the safety valve disappears, IATA wants adequate border staffing, stable hardware and software, fully operational self-service kiosks and automated gates, and wider deployment of pre-registration apps. Moving more registration away from airport border desks is the quickest way to ease queues, it argues, while better data-sharing between governments, airports and airlines would help identify where the system is failing.

MARITIME

RUSSIAN SHIP PUT ON ICE IN SVALBARD: Norwegian authorities have seized a Russian commercial vessel in the Arctic at Ukraine's request, opening a new front in Kyiv's global effort to enforce a \$4.22 billion arbitration award over assets Russia confiscated after annexing Crimea.

Stuck in port: The expedition cruise vessel "Professor Molchanov" has been barred from leaving Barentsburg following an Aug. 31 order from Norway's Nord-Troms district court. Ukraine's state-owned energy company Naftogaz requested the seizure after Moscow refused to pay the award.

The backstory: A tribunal in The Hague ruled in 2023 that Russia must compensate Naftogaz for unlawfully taking gas fields, pipelines and other energy assets in Crimea. Naftogaz has since been asking national courts to attach Russian commercial property around the world.

Arctic precedent: The action is particularly important because it took place in Svalbard, a strategically sensitive Arctic archipelago where Russia maintains a presence in the settlement of Barentsburg. The vessel is used for commercial expedition cruises, including voyages around Svalbard.

Cold timing: The seizure comes as Putin is pushing to turn Russia's Northern Sea Route into a year-round shipping corridor. He said at the plenary session of the Eastern Economic Forum on Thursday that Moscow is expanding its icebreaker and ice-class fleets, rescue services, satellites and port infrastructure, while preparing a transport-development plan running to 2050 and the first oil shipments from the new Bukhta Sever terminal. The episode adds another legal and geopolitical complication to Russia's drive to expand commercial activity across the High North.

TRADE

BEIJING HITS BACK ON TRADE THREATS: "Unilateral demands, conditions, or even the threat of market closures should be avoided." That was the message from Chinese Commerce Ministry spokesperson Huang Ling in response to a question on European Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič's threat to close EU markets should EU-China trade talks go south.

Redonnet readout: The reply comes shortly after DG TRADE Deputy Director Denis Redonnet returns from Beijing after three days of trade talks, our colleague Camille Gijs reports. Ling described the talks as "in-depth, frank, and constructive" while emphasizing that there would be "multiple rounds" of consultations (which suggests that there are no breakthroughs yet).

Blame game: The commerce ministry representative didn't shy away from more pointed remarks. According to Ling, it was important that Brussels "face up to its own problems." "China is not the root cause of these problems, but rather a partner that can help the EU resolve them," he added.

Who's fault is it? Where the relative blame lies for the €1 billion-a-day trade deficit has become a key point in the discussion. The EU maintains that China's industrial subsidies are juicing exports to unsustainable levels, which are having an outsized impact on its automotive sector. Beijing hits back that its companies are operating at the technological frontier, and that this is sour grapes from the increasingly obsolete continent.

PIT STOPS

American ride-hailing company Uber is cutting 10 percent of its global staff as part of a restructuring that is meant to put more money toward its developing robo-taxi business.

Headlines

Here's a recap of yesterday's news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

Germany's far right gains off VW troubles

The far-right Alternative for Germany is blaming the government of Chancellor Friedrich Merz and the EU for VW's difficulties.

By Jordyn Dahl · Sept 03, 2026, 07:14 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

Burnham and Macron agree to 'find a way forward' on 'Made in Europe' rules

By Sophie Inge · Sept 03, 2026, 05:00 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

Document: Truckers, green groups team up to demand EU truck dialogue

By Martina Sapio · Sept 03, 2026, 10:29 am Europe/Brussels CEST

Weekly Calendar

Here's a selection of upcoming key events, find the complete Week Ahead online.

Pro Roundtable – Tech

Sep 8, 2026, 8:15 AM - 10:00 am

CANSO Euro-Asia ANSP's CEO Summit

Sep 9, 2026 - Sep 10, 2026 · Tashkent, UZ

EIT Urban Mobility North Summit

Sep 9, 2026 - Sep 10, 2026 · Oslo, NO

European Commission 'International Ship Autonomy and Sustainability Summit'

Sep 10, 2026 · Malmö, SE

Pro Roundtable – Energy & Climate

Sep 10, 2026, 8:15 AM - 10:00 am

Eurocontrol Air Navigation Services Board Working Group

Sep 11, 2026, 9:00 AM - 12:00 pm · Brussels, BE

European Parliament plenary session

Sep 14, 2026 - Sep 17, 2026 · Strasbourg, FR

Pro Intelligence Connections

2021/0211(COD) Revision of the EU Emissions Tradin...

Discussions within the Council or its preparatory...

2021/0207(COD) Revision of the EU Emissions Tradin...

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